



recollects. From Bombay, the journey continued to Kanpur. In those days, air travel wasn't the norm, and Burki recalls that separate train bogies were reserved for the Indian and Pakistan teams. "There was a different excitement," he says.

Once the second Test got underway in Kanpur, Burki played a gritty innings of 79 before being run out. "On that tour, I always contributed when my team was in trouble, and the innings in Kanpur was one such occasion," he says. "When we played the fourth Test in Madras (now Chennai), the wicket had become very easy to bat on. By the time my turn came, I had no interest, and I was out quickly... But I always performed under pressure."

While he recalls that most wickets were placid, the one at Eden Gardens favoured the bowlers. "I thought this was a Test where we could maybe get India on the run. It was a wicket where he (Mahmood) could work. On the other grassless turf wickets, he couldn't do anything. But in Calcutta, where the ball gripped a little, I thought we could get things done. So

when I went in, I went for the Indian bowling and played a quickfire innings," he says.

However, Pakistan's captain, Mahmood, did not press for a win. "Back in those days, the mentality was to not lose. And we were not trying to win. Both teams were afraid of losing..." Burki remembers how the Pakistan batters looked comfortable against India's medium pacers, Surendra Nath and Ramakant Desai.

Before breaking into the Pakistan team, Burki had played against a touring Indian team for Oxford, where he scored a century.

"That experience helped. I had previously played against Gupte and Chandu Borde, so I'd already seen all these boys on a sporting wicket in Oxford. And here I was, playing against them on these very easy wickets. So it wasn't much of a problem," he says.

Feeling at home

The touring team had little trouble adapting to conditions, but the Pakistan players encountered an unforeseen predicament upon arriving in Madras for the fourth Test

— finding familiar food. "Some of us from the north, northwest, were not able to eat too much rice. We were sort of wheat eaters. And in Madras in those days, nobody had ever heard of chapati. We tried to explain to the gentleman in the kitchen, and they whipped up something from white flour," Burki recalls, adding, "We ended up eating a lot of rice..."

Born in Meerut in undivided India, the tour of India felt like a homecoming for Burki. However, as a youngster, it was also about acclimatising to international cricket. "The cultures were not different. And for me, it was not different at all," he says. "I was born in Meerut, and our family, we were Afghans. We had 12 fortified villages outside Jalandhar, and I came to Pakistan in October or November of 1947 from Lucknow. So this was new for me, but not India, so that tour was a great moment for me," he adds.

Pakistan's team at the time was a product of the Ranji Trophy, with several of its players having gained considerable First-Class experience in undivided India. Burki believes that